

Random Thoughts

Civilization



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RANDOM THOUGHTS ON CIVILIZATION

by *Galanda Sweya*

Part I: What is Civilization

Civilization refers to a complex human society characterized by the development of urban centers, advanced social structures, specialized labor, centralized governance, and cultural achievements such as writing, art, and technology.

It is hard and totally impossible for one human to run the world without everyone else because we just can't do everything; manufacture, maintain, repair and protect. So, it is inevitable for humans to collaborate and work together to make survival (the primary goal of humans) to be achievable. Even for reproduction it requires humans to work together to grow the population.

Well organized civilizations are most likely to succeed then the disorganized one, and this may not apply for the entire population and rather a subset of it, which of course stems from the economic policies that are existent in the society that favor different characteristics and attributes for a person to succeed in the given civilization.

In my opinion, one of the greatest studies of civilization has been on the Greeks. The Greeks I think have been one of the greatest demonstrations of civilizational structures and how humans should co-exist with their environment to produce a meaningful life. From the great stories of the gods, that have existed in their timelines to the ideas of the Greek philosophers on the various aspects of life, they have contributed a lot of ideas that have shaped the systems of today's worlds that proceed to carry our civilizations.

When I speak of civilizations, I refer to: countries. Because I think a large generalization of this to the entire world makes sense, but there exist major differences between countries in terms of how we conduct ourselves.

Part II: Aspects of Civilization

Civilizations can be dissected into the following spheres of existence or operation

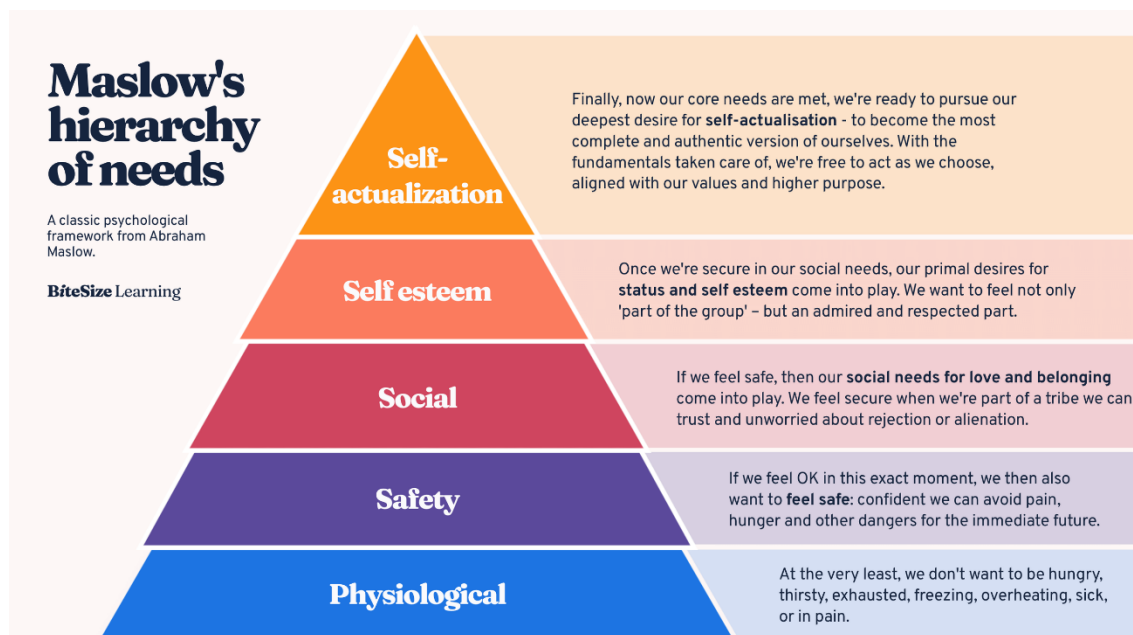
Economic Sphere

This is essentially the bedrock of civilizations. Every civilization requires economic ground for its survival. The primary drive and need of human beings are to survive. In brief, the economy comprises of goods and services, we need goods to satisfy our needs and services to meet the other derived wants or needs we have created for ourselves. The existence of these goods and services is triggered by value generated by humans over them.

So essentially when we purchase a product or pay for a service, its because we value it and we want to obtain satisfaction from using it or having possession of it. To produce these goods, it requires proper coordination of: capital, energy, labor and markets.

Proper economic systems stabilize societies, because it meets their demands and wants. Satisfaction of the basic needs of humans, fosters the creation of luxuries which signify a state of met wants and needs and good welfare.

The following table quickly summarizes, the growth direction of



Source: <https://www.bitesizelearning.co.uk/resources/maslows-hierarchy-of-needs-theory>

Satisfaction of the bigger needs at the bottom drives for the demand of more things on a higher level. In the personal MBA, Josh Kaufman, explains well how these can be used to derive different businesses because they're what humans essentially find valuable. So for instance with social and self-esteem needs have driven for the growth of social media platforms that we see today.

Social Sphere

Civilizations are also built around culture, religion, education, family structures, and social norms. These are very important because they play pivotal role in creating social cohesion. Social cohesion comes through shared identities, rituals and institutions but stratification or formation of classes are what create inequalities in the society and can lead to internal tensions.

Humans at the core of it, are very social beings it is just our nature. And in our search for answers to the world that we exist in (as in by nature all humans are curious) and it is why babies even grow to walk and learn to interact, because of this inborn nature of ourselves. We experiment a lot.

And so, we have derived, many conjectures (educated guesses of explanations for what is going on in our world). And that is why we have so many religions. I think it is nature that we are created to serve or answer to a higher being which influences our yearn for spiritual connections. These play a pivotal role in our society because they shape the way we live with each other, and it is essential for bonding humans to work together.

If we don't have good social grounds, then essentially there exists no love, that is critical for the formation of families, nor is there love to allow us to work together for the welfare of the society.

One of things I congratulate Mwalimu Julius Kambarage Nyerere the founder of my nation, was his ability to join more than 120 tribes which represent many ethnicities, different philosophies and views of life in harmony to co-exist with each other in ways that people are working together today.

Many civilizations break from the loss of social groundings that exist to keep people together, as though they may not be perfect, but degradation of these may bring civilizations down. There are many talks around the world on immigrants, and in my opinion, I think it is up to the country to decide for itself, but as for the immigrant, when moving to a new society it's obligatory to tune it to their culture. A deviation from it is what breaks the existing cohesion and leads to the collapse of these societies.

In Steven Bartlett's *The Diary of A CEO*, he writes; "if the culture is strong, the people become the culture, if the culture is weak the culture becomes like the people."

Political Sphere

Civilizations require structure to prevent chaos. If everyone was free to do what they wanted, then society would break, because without rules there exists no order. I would be unfair or injustice for someone else to be able to harm you without a repercussion for their own actions.

The rise of governance, laws, power distribution, and control mechanisms have been influenced by the instincts of human beings ourselves, and they've been influenced by our own cultures and normalized ways of living.

There are many systems such as monarchies, republics or empires, that have worked to organize the resources available to create a good welfare for the general public. Policies that drive everyday life including education heavily rely on having good political structures that prevent the abuse of power and misuse of resources for the greedy minority.

It is almost hard to leave the greed of power. Many leaders and political figures have fallen prey of this, forcing to lead their nations for unprecedented number of times, however some countries have been saved by their termed conditions and lowered concentration of power to one body.

Surveillance of the society has also grown across the years with the growth of technologies that support other governments to keep an eye on their societies to prevent possible

government overthrows which could take them out of power and destabilize their authority.

*Education

I want to make a special mention of education and the role it plays in the growth of civilizations. Human resources are the most important resource to any nation, over any other resource that exists.

To meet the economic demands of the civilization, it should be able to manufacture, maintain, improve and secure resources around it. And it requires knowledge to be able to do all these things together.

Education is critical for the society; it is how we learn about all the aspects in society and how to come about with them. Most times people tend to confuse education with school. School is just an institute that provides education and it existed as it was hard to easily access it in the past, but today it is available through the internet.

We can now easily communicate and share information across many domains with people from anywhere around the world. Knowledge can also be obtained from our own curiosity and studying the world.

Knowledge is the cap of what the civilization can do. If it is not knowledgeable enough to utilize the resources around it, it will fall to its deepest lows.

Part III: Prosperity of a Civilization

Civilizations grow and eventually die when they fail to keep up working systems. In my opinion a civilization's prosperity depends on how it manages to organize all its aspects for success.

It needs to utilize the economic factors that it has to generate a strong economy, which can enable it to provide for itself. One that is free to allow anyone to generate wealth and attain individual success is favorable.

However, another key element to this is time preference. With time preference a civilization forgoes the short-term gains it may gain today for the possibility of gaining higher rewards in the future. And it is how many civilizations have come to strong positions in terms of welfare.

Forgoing the short-term gains of enjoyment and working hard has created wealth for many countries that hold wealth today. However, there may be a debate on how much of this generated wealth has benefited the civilization as a whole.

It is critical for a society to always provide the right rewards to incentivize good actions, because incentivizing the wrong actions can significantly derail civilizations. For instance, in today's communities, being famous is being rewarded as being more important or having money than actually providing real value. Which has driven people to chase money for the wrong reasons, and even promoting bad actions in the name of acquiring wealth for respect and I think it will significantly destroy a lot of lives and the moral grounds that have existed. * I don't mean to say money is not important, but there should be a boundary of how far we go to get it.

Economics of scalability is something that also has to be deeply exploited for success. In terms of population throughput and value creation. It is hard for everyone to be the same, the bell curve. Well, the truth is there is no equal distribution of traits like strength, charismatic, insider or hero traits all of the sorts of "talents". Most people are average, and it is the hard truth that exists.

Which comes as a result of nature, though I do believe certain gaps can be closed but gaps do exist by nature, and proper organization can help each of these different traits co-exist and produce their own values to society.

It's why having a large population size can also significantly increase the chances of success of a society. Because having more people increases the probabilities of having people with these traits. And in my opinion, every skill that is learnable can be taught through education to replicate the population's skillset and the variety of what it can produce to position itself for favorable economic rewards.

And the more the society reaps can be returned to benefit as a whole.

Part IV: Collapse of Civilizations

Civilizations evolve as time proceeds. It may grow significantly and evolve to something else, or may come to a collapse. Both actions do not take place at a sudden. And occur as a cumulation of stress and becomes amplified by the effect or political powers.

The collapse of civilizations can be caused by economic factors such as resource depletion or trade disruptions that lead to famine and unrest.

In terms of social aspects, inequality and social conflicts or cultural shifts may trigger decline of civilizations.

Politically, overextension of power, corruption and fragmented control over society can shake powerful systems out of place creating disorder in the society.

External factors such as invasions, and climate change or technological lags can significantly bring down a civilization. New technological breakthroughs can also trigger new changes to society which may drive for new ways of existence.

Technology essentially shapes the way we live. It dictates how we choose to do things, from communication, to production, and running everyday activities. Technology gives people new abilities; it allows them to do more form what was achieved in the past societies. In the long term this fuels the higher order of the civilizations to do more and live different.

In my opinion: AI will significantly do the same, the abilities and dependencies that exist in society, will break. We depended on humans for a lot of things which bonded us, especially knowledge and the ability to do certain actions were limited to a few individuals, the technology may not mature enough, but I think people will inevitably rely less on humans compared to the past. The power that AI unlocks, will give civilization to do so much more as well.

But as long as we choose ourselves, do everything in the favor for all humans. The new era that the world walks into is scary as all aspects of society are on a brink at once, but only the choices we make will determine the outcome.